

Anchoring Price Experiment Teacher Notes

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • Human Sciences • 20-30 min

Category	Human Sciences	Time	20-30 min
Difficulty	Easy	ID	anchoring-price-experiment

Big idea: Human judgement can be pulled by context even when the context is not valid evidence.

Overview

Students estimate values after seeing different anchors and evaluate how irrelevant numbers shape judgement.

Student Prompt

Inspect Anchoring Price Experiment Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Anchoring Price Experiment Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: High anchor: Is this backpack worth more or less than \$180? Estimate its value. Predict how people will respond, then identify the wording, context, incentive, or role that could change the result.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Anchoring Price Experiment Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: Low anchor: Is this backpack worth more or less than \$25? Estimate its value. Predict how people will respond, then identify the wording, context, incentive, or role that could change the result.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Anchoring Price Experiment Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: Low anchor: Is this backpack worth more or less than \$25? Estimate its value. Predict how people will respond, then identify the wording, context, incentive, or role that could change the result.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Human judgement can be pulled by context even when the context is not valid evidence.

Actual Lesson Questions and Key

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
1	After inspecting Anchoring Price Experiment Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: look for a clear claim, not just a description.
2	Which exact detail from Anchoring Price Experiment Stimulus A did you use as evidence?	Teacher cue: students should name visible words, data, source features, method features, or contextual clues.
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?	Teacher cue: this is where assumptions, framing, models, or perspective usually appear.
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?	Teacher cue: confidence is data for the debrief, not a grade.
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: push for method, source, context, comparison, or definitions.

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
6	Can knowers fully explain their own judgements?	Teacher cue: students should move from the classroom example to a general TOK issue.

Teacher Key / Reveal

The key move is not the “right answer”; it is the moment students see how human judgement can be pulled by context even when the context is not valid evidence.

- Strong response: separates observation from inference.
- Strong response: names a method, source, model, language choice, context, or perspective.
- Strong response: revises confidence when new evidence or a new criterion appears.
- Weak response: gives only opinion or says “it depends” without criteria.

Setup Checklist

- Randomly distribute high-anchor and low-anchor sheets without announcing the difference.
- Use estimates where students are unlikely to know the exact answer.

Ready-to-Use Examples

- High anchor: Is this backpack worth more or less than \$180? Estimate its value.
- Low anchor: Is this backpack worth more or less than \$25? Estimate its value.

Suggested Timing

Stage	Teacher move	Watch for
1	Randomly give students a high-anchor or low-anchor version of the sheet.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
2	Students answer whether the true value is higher or lower than the anchor.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
3	Students then give their best estimate.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
4	Compare average estimates across anchor groups.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
5	Debrief why irrelevant numbers can influence judgement.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
Debrief	Move from the activity result to a TOK knowledge question.	Students distinguishing method, evidence, interpretation, and overclaiming.

Teacher Language

- The anchor was not evidence, but it still entered the judgement.
- How could a human scientist show that the context caused a difference?

Common Misconceptions

- Students may treat class behaviour as universal human nature.
- Students may ignore ethical limits or context effects in human-subject inquiry.

Assessment Look-Fors

- Connects behaviour to method, context, incentives, and ethical constraints.
- Avoids overgeneralising from one small sample.

Differentiation and Adaptations

- Support: use one object and two anchor sheets.
- Challenge: add a no-anchor control group.

Extension Tasks

- Students design a follow-up experiment with random assignment and a control group.
- Connect anchoring to pricing, negotiation, sentencing, or predicted grades.

Related Activities

- Survey Wording Experiment
- Ultimatum Game
- Conformity without Humiliation